

javelins and swords. However, almost as soon as Sparta emerged victorious in 404BCE, its power was challenged by the Thebans, led by Epaminondas.

THE EVOLUTION OF THE PHALANX

The Thebans deepened their phalanxes to 12 ranks or more, made greater use of cavalry, and trained an elite force known as the Sacred Band. This helped them win a stunning victory at Leuctra, in 371BCE, which broke Spartan supremacy. However, Theban

dominance was short-lived and Greece fell into civil wars, ending with the rise of Macedon, first under Philip II and then Alexander the Great.

The Macedonians further deepened the phalanx to 16 ranks, and their soldiers carried the *sarissa*, a longer spear of up to 6m (20 feet), which allowed the first five rows to strike at the enemy. These armoured “phalangites” kept enemy infantry pinned down, while heavy cavalry, slingers, and peltasts launched their attack.

“Like some ferocious beast as it turns at bay and stiffens its bristles”

PLUTARCH, DESCRIBING THE APPEARANCE OF A PHALANX, c.100CE



KEY EVENTS

725–300BCE

■ **c.725–700BCE** The earliest known war between Greek city-states (the Lelantine War between Chalcis and Eretria) is thought to have been fought in this period. Hoplite armour is also thought to originate in this era.

■ **c.650BCE** The earliest depiction of hoplites in art shows them without swords, but carrying two spears: one for thrusting and one for throwing.

■ **492–90BCE** The first Greco-Persian War takes place. Darius I of Persia invades Greece, attracting some allies in the north, but is defeated by the Athenians and their Plataean allies at the Battle of Marathon (490BCE), in which the Plataean hoplites surprise the Persians by charging into their ranks.

■ **431–04BCE** Spartan and Athenian forces clash in the Peloponnesian War.

■ **480BCE** Xerxes launches the second Persian invasion of Greece. The Persians are delayed by Spartan resistance at Thermopylae (480BCE). They are then defeated at Salamis (480BCE) by the Athenian navy, and at Plataea (479BCE), where Spartan hoplites break through the Persian line, causing the Persian army to flee.

■ **378BCE** The Thebans, under Epaminondas, destroy the Spartan army at the Battle of Leuctra, marking the beginning of the eclipse of traditional hoplite forces.

■ **338BCE** At Chaeronea, Philip II of Macedon defeats the Thebans by feigning a withdrawal, stretching one wing of the Theban army in pursuit. Philip's son, Alexander, then charges the enemy's left wing with cavalry, routing it. The Theban Sacred Band is destroyed.

■ **331BCE** The Battle of Gaugamela takes place. A Macedonian attack on the left wing of the Persian army, opens up a gap in their ranks, into which Alexander advances. This flexible approach is far in advance of traditional hoplite tactics.

◀ A HOPLITE CHARGE

This vase shows Greek hoplites running into battle, their Corinthian helmets, horsehair crests, bronze greaves, and spears clearly visible. The artist has not depicted the other ranks in the phalanx, which made it even more intimidating to behold.